
Software Requirements Specification

For

Film Festival Submission & Screening Portal

Version 1.0 approved

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AUGUST 4, 2026

Table of Contents

	Table of Contents	
	Revision History	
1.	Introduction	1
1.1	Purpose	1
1.2	Document Conventions	1
1.3	Intended Audience and Reading Suggestions	1
1.4	Product Scope	1
1.5	References	1
2	Overall Description	2
2.1	Product Perspective	2
2.2	Product Functions	2
2.3	User Classes and Characteristics	2
2.4	Operating Environment	2
2.5	Design and Implementation Constraints	3
2.6	User Documentation	3
2.7	Assumptions and Dependencies	3
3	External Interface Requirements	4
3.1	User Interfaces	4
3.2	Hardware Interfaces	4
3.3	Software Interfaces	4
3.4	Communications Interfaces	4
4	System Features	5
4.1	Role-Based Registration & Login	5
4.2	Film Submission	5
4.3	Auto Eligibility Check	6
4.4	Manual Jury Assignment	6

4.5	Blind Review Mode	7
4.6	Weighted Multi-Criteria Scoring	7
4.7	Automatic Aggregate Scoring & Shortlist Generation	8
4.8	Mandatory Pre-Vote Discussion	8
4.9	Final Voting	9
4.10	Tie Detection & Tie-Break	9
4.11	Admin Confirm & Publish	9
4.12	Post-Publish Result & Comment Visibility	10
4.13	Notification System	10
4.14	Admin Audit Trail	11
4.15	Festival Creation & Management	11
5	Other Nonfunctional Requirements	12
5.1	Performance Requirements	12
5.2	Safety Requirements	12
5.3	Security Requirements	12
5.4	Software Quality Attributes	12
5.5	Business Rules	13
6	Other Requirements	13
	Appendix A: Glossary	13
	Appendix B: Analysis Models	14
	Appendix C: To Be Determined List	14

Revision History

Name	Date	Reason For Changes	Version

1. Introduction

1.1 Purpose

This document specifies the software requirements for Version 1.0 of the Film Festival Submission & Screening Portal, a web-based platform for a college film club / student festival committee. It covers the complete workflow from film submission through blind jury review, weighted scoring, mandatory jury discussion, voting, and private communication of results to filmmakers. This SRS describes the entire system; there are no separate subsystem documents at this stage.

1.2 Document Conventions

Functional requirements are tagged REQ-<feature>.<n> (e.g., REQ-2.3 is the third requirement under Feature 2). Each System Feature in Section 4 is assigned a priority of High, Medium, or Low, reflecting its necessity for a usable V1.0 release. Struck-through or superseded functionality from earlier drafts (public/audience-facing pages and native video-file hosting) has been removed from this version rather than marked TBD, since these were deliberate scope decisions, not open items.

1.3 Intended Audience and Reading Suggestions

This document is intended for: the development team (implementers of each increment), the course instructor/evaluator assessing the project, and any peer reviewers acting as test Jury/Admin users. Readers new to the project should start with Section 2 (Overall Description) for context, then read Section 4 (System Features) for feature-level detail. Developers implementing a specific increment can go directly to the corresponding subsection of Section 4.

1.4 Product Scope

The Portal replaces the club's current ad hoc process (Google Forms, WhatsApp groups, spreadsheets) with a single role-based web application for Filmmakers, Jury members, and an Admin. Core objectives: give filmmakers visibility into submission status; let the Admin assign films to jury fairly; keep scoring unbiased through blind review; and reach a festival winner through a structured process that combines weighted scoring with mandatory jury discussion, rather than either pure algorithmic ranking or an unstructured live meeting. Once a winner is confirmed and published, each shortlisted filmmaker gains visibility into the anonymized discussion comments on their own film, for transparency and future career use. V1.0 deliberately excludes any public-facing results or voting page, and native video-file hosting, all film content is linked externally, and all results and discussion access are communicated privately to the relevant filmmaker.

References

- Wiegers, K. E., "Software Requirements Specification Template," 1999.
- IEEE Std 830-1998, IEEE Recommended Practice for Software Requirements Specifications.
- Project scoping discussion, SE Mini Project group chat, 2026 (source of the finalized functional requirements in Section 4).

2. Overall Description

2.1 Product Perspective

The Portal is a new, self-contained web application. It is not a follow-on to an existing system; it replaces a manual, spreadsheet-and-chat-based process currently used by the film club. It has no dependency on a larger enterprise system and exposes no external API to other software in V1.0.

2.2 Product Functions

At a high level, the system lets a Filmmaker register submit a film (poster uploaded directly; trailer and full film linked externally via YouTube/Google Drive), and track its status. It lets an Admin assign films to Jury members. It lets Jury members review films blind, score them against a weighted rubric, participate in mandatory discussion, and vote. It automatically aggregates scores into a shortlist, resolves ties through a scoped discussion-and-revote cycle, and lets the Admin confirm and publish the final result — after which the relevant filmmaker gains visibility into their film's anonymized discussion comments. Full detail is in Section 4.

2.3 User Classes and Characteristics

- **Filmmaker:** Submits films and tracks status. No technical expertise assumed. Registers directly as Filmmaker; this role is fixed and does not change. Gains read-only access to the discussion thread and final result for their own film only, after the Admin publishes.
- **Non-Filmmaker:** Registers as a general user who has not committed to a specific role. Becomes an **Admin** for a given festival by creating it, or becomes a **Jury member** for a given festival by requesting to join and being approved by that festival's Admin.
- **Jury Member:** A Non-Filmmaker approved to review a specific festival. Reviews assigned films, scores them, discusses shortlisted films, and votes. Requests festival participation; does not self-provision review access.
- **Admin:** A Non-Filmmaker who created a specific festival. Manages that festival's jury requests, assignment, shortlist oversight, and confirms/publishes results. Privilege is scoped to the festival they created, not global.

2.4 Operating Environment

Client: any modern desktop or mobile web browser (Chrome, Firefox, Edge, Safari) over a responsive layout; no native app or installation required. Server: Apache Tomcat servlet container with a MySQL database, accessed via JDBC. No cloud object storage is used — trailer and full-film content are linked externally rather than hosted on the platform.

2.5 Design and Implementation Constraints

- Built using Java Servlets/JSP, HTML/CSS/JavaScript with Bootstrap, and MySQL, matching the development team's existing skill set.
- Trailers and full films are linked externally (YouTube, Google Drive); the platform does not host or stream video files directly.
- Only the poster image is uploaded directly to and stored by the application.
- No public-facing pages exist; there is no audience voting or public results catalogue.
- Voting is gated: a Jury member's vote is not accepted until they have commented on every shortlisted film.
- Team and timeline constraint: a 3-person team building within a single academic term, which is why the system is developed using the Incremental process model, one complete module at a time.
- A shortlisted film's discussion thread becomes visible to that film's Filmmaker only after the Admin publishes the final result.

2.6 User Documentation

V1.0 will ship with in-app contextual help (tooltips and short inline instructions) on each role's dashboard. A separate user manual is not planned for this release; it is listed as a candidate item in Appendix C.

2.7 Assumptions and Dependencies

- Assumes all users have reliable internet access during submission, review, and voting windows.
- Assumes Jury members participate in the mandatory discussion step in good faith (the system checks that a comment exists, not that it is substantive).

3. External Interface Requirements

3.1 User Interfaces

Each role has a dedicated dashboard reached after login:

- Filmmaker dashboard (submission form, status tracker, notifications, and once published the discussion thread and final result for their own film)
- Jury dashboard (assigned films, blind-review scoring screen, discussion thread, voting screen)
- Admin dashboard (jury assignment, shortlist view, discussion monitor, tie-break controls, confirm-and-publish action).

All screens share a common header/navigation and follow a consistent, responsive layout across desktop and mobile widths.

3.2 Hardware Interfaces

None beyond a standard internet-connected client device (desktop, laptop, tablet, or phone) with a modern web browser. No camera, microphone, or specialized peripheral is required, since discussion is text-based and asynchronous.

3.3 Software Interfaces

- MySQL database, accessed via JDBC, stores users, submissions, scores, discussion comments, votes, and notification records.
- Apache Tomcat as the servlet container hosting the web application.
- External film-hosting services (YouTube, Google Drive), accessed only via hyperlinks, no API integration required.
- Payment gateway API (sandbox/test mode), processes registration payment as the final step film submission; verified server-side via webhook.

3.4 Communications Interfaces

All client-server communication uses HTTPS. V1.0 supports in-app notifications only; email or SMS integration is not included; no real-time messaging protocol is required, since the jury discussion feature is asynchronous and page-refresh based rather than live chat.

4. System Features

Functional requirements are organized below by system features in the order a submission moves through the workflow:

Registration → Festival creation → Submission → Eligibility → Jury assignment → Blind review → Scoring → Shortlist → Discussion → Voting → Tie-break → Publish → Notification.

4.1 Role-Based Registration & Login

4.1.1 Description and Priority

Allows a user to register as either a Filmmaker or a Non-Filmmaker. A Non-Filmmaker becomes an Admin by creating a festival, or a Jury member by requesting and being approved to join a specific-festival.

Priority: High

4.1.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

User visits the site and registers as either Filmmaker or Non-Filmmaker. A Non-Filmmaker who creates a festival is granted Admin privileges scoped to that festival. A Non-Filmmaker who requests to join a festival as Jury is granted Jury privileges for that festival only after Admin approval. On successful authentication, the system routes the user to their role-specific dashboard.

4.1.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-1.1: The system shall allow a user to self-register as either Filmmaker or Non-Filmmaker.

REQ-1.2: The system shall grant Admin privileges, scoped to a specific festival, to a Non-Filmmaker upon creating that festival.

REQ-1.3: The system shall route each authenticated user to the dashboard associated with their role.

REQ-1.4: The system shall require authentication for access to any role-specific page.

REQ-1.5: The system shall grant Jury privileges, scoped to a specific festival, to a Non-Filmmaker only after Admin approval of their request for that festival.

4.2 Film Submission

4.2.1 Description and Priority

Lets a Filmmaker submit a film by uploading a poster image and providing external links to the trailer and full film (YouTube or Google Drive). No video files are uploaded to or hosted by the platform.

Priority: High

4.2.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Filmmaker opens the submission form for a festival/category, uploads a poster image, enters trailer and full-film links, and submits. The system validates the links and stores the submission, confirming with a tracking ID.

4.2.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-2.1: The system shall require title, genre, duration, synopsis, an external trailer link, an external full-film link, and a poster image for each submission.

REQ-2.2: The system shall validate that the trailer and full-film links are well-formed URLs pointing to a supported host (YouTube or Google Drive).

REQ-2.3: The system shall restrict the poster upload to standard image formats (JPEG/PNG) under a defined file-size cap.

REQ-2.4: The system shall store the poster file on the application server and persist only the trailer and full-film URLs (not video files) in the database.

REQ-2.5: The system shall display a confirmation message with a tracking ID upon successful submission.

REQ-2.6: The system shall require a completed registration payment as the final step of film submission, via a payment gateway integration.

REQ-2.7: The system shall verify payment status server-side via the gateway's webhook/callback; a client-side redirect alone shall not be treated as proof of payment.

REQ-2.8: The system shall reject a submission as incomplete if payment is not successfully confirmed.

4.3 Auto Eligibility Check

4.3.1 Description and Priority

Automatically validates a new submission against category rules, so ineligible submissions are flagged before jury assignment. This check no longer includes any payment/fee validation, since submissions are free.

Priority: High

4.3.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Immediately after a Filmmaker submits, the system evaluates the submission against eligibility rules (runtime limit, genre/category match, submission deadline) and returns a pass/fail result with a reason.

4.3.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-3.1: The system shall validate a submission's runtime and category against the rules defined for the selected festival category.

REQ-3.2: The system shall reject submissions received after the published submission deadline.

REQ-3.3: The system shall notify the Filmmaker of the eligibility result immediately after submission.

REQ-3.4: The system shall confirm that registration payment was successfully completed before a submission proceeds to eligibility checks.

4.4 Manual Jury Assignment

4.4.1 Description and Priority

Gives the Admin a manual control to assign each eligible film to one or more Jury members, so review workload is distributed intentionally rather than automatically.

Priority: High

4.4.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Admin opens the assignment screen after the submission window closes, selects an eligible film, and assigns it to one or more Jury members. The assigned Jury member is notified.

4.4.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-4.1: The system shall let the Admin view all submissions that passed the eligibility check.

REQ-4.2: The system shall let the Admin manually assign a film to one or more Jury members.

REQ-4.3: The system shall prevent assignment of a submission that failed the eligibility check.

REQ-4.4: The system shall notify a Jury member when a new film is assigned to them.

REQ-4.5: The system shall restrict jury assignment to Jury members approved for that specific festival.

4.5 Blind Review Mode

4.5.1 Description and Priority

Hides filmmaker identity and identifying metadata from the Jury while they review and score an assigned film, to keep scoring unbiased.

Priority: High

4.5.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Jury member opens an assigned film for review. The system displays the film content, a film title/code, and the scoring rubric, but never the filmmaker's name or other identifying metadata.

4.5.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-5.1: The system shall withhold the filmmaker's name and other identifying metadata from the Jury's review and scoring screens.

REQ-5.2: The system shall display only a non-identifying film title/code, the film content, and the scoring rubric during Jury review.

REQ-5.3: Identity-hiding shall be enforced server-side (the API response itself must omit identity fields for the Jury role), not only hidden in the UI.

4.6 Weighted Multi-Criteria Scoring

4.6.1 Description and Priority

Let a Jury member score an assigned film against a rubric of multiple weighted criteria (e.g., story, direction, technical quality), and computes that Jury member's weighted total.

Priority: High

4.6.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Jury member fills in a score for each rubric criterion and submits. The system validates completeness and computes the weighted total for that Jury member and film.

4.6.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-6.1: The system shall present a rubric of multiple scoring criteria, each with a predefined weight, for every film under review.

REQ-6.2: The system shall require a score for every rubric criterion before a scoring submission is accepted.

REQ-6.3: The system shall automatically compute each Jury member's weighted total score for a film from their per-criterion scores.

REQ-6.4: The system shall allow a Jury member to edit their submitted score for a film until the scoring window closes.

4.7 Automatic Aggregate Scoring & Shortlist Generation

4.7.1 Description and Priority

Aggregates weighted scores across all Jury members assigned to a film once the scoring window closes, and automatically generates a ranked Top 5 shortlist.

Priority: High

4.7.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Scoring window closes. The system aggregates each film's weighted scores across all assigned Jury members, ranks all films, and generates a Top 5 shortlist visible to Jury and Admin.

4.7.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-7.1: The system shall aggregate the weighted scores from all Jury members assigned to a film into a single aggregate score per film.

REQ-7.2: The system shall rank all eligible films by aggregate score and automatically generate a ranked Top 5 shortlist.

REQ-7.3: The system shall restrict visibility of the shortlist to the Jury and Admin roles until the Admin publishes the final result.

4.8 Mandatory Pre-Vote Discussion

4.8.1 Description and Priority

Requires every Jury member and the Admin to discuss each shortlisted film in a shared, time-boxed comment thread before that participant is permitted to vote, ensuring the final vote is informed rather than purely score-driven.

Priority: Medium

4.8.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Shortlist is generated. The system opens one comment thread per shortlisted film, visible to Jury and Admin during the discussion phase.. A participant's Vote action stays disabled until they have commented on every shortlisted film, or until the 48-hour window closes.

4.8.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-8.1: The system shall open one discussion thread per shortlisted film, visible only to Jury members and the Admin during the active discussion and voting phases

REQ-8.2: The system shall require each Jury member and the Admin to post at least one comment on every shortlisted film before their Vote action is enabled.

REQ-8.3: The system shall keep the Vote action disabled for any participant who has not met the comment requirement.

REQ-8.4: The system shall automatically close the discussion window 48 hours after shortlist generation and send a reminder notification before closing.

4.9 Final Voting

4.9.1 Description and Priority

Let's each Jury member and the Admin cast exactly one vote for their preferred film among the Top 5, after discussion, and prevents vote manipulation such as repeat voting or bandwagon effects.

Priority: High

4.9.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Discussion window closes (or a participant has met the comment requirement). The system enables that participant's Vote action. The participant selects one film from the Top 5 and submits their vote.

4.9.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-9.1: The system shall allow each Jury member and the Admin to cast exactly one vote for one film among the Top 5 shortlisted films.

REQ-9.2: The system shall prevent a participant from voting more than once or from changing their vote after submission.

REQ-9.3: The system shall not display running vote counts to any Jury member or Admin before the final tally is complete.

4.10 Tie Detection & Tie-Break

4.10.1 Description and Priority

Automatically detects a tie in the final vote tally and resolves it through a short, scoped second discussion-and-revote cycle, falling back to the Admin's vote if the tie persists.

Priority: Medium

4.10.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Voting closes. The system tallies votes. If two or more films are tied for the highest vote count, the system opens a second discussion thread scoped only to the tied films, open for 24 hours, followed by a revote restricted to those films.

4.10.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-10.1: The system shall automatically detect when two or more films are tied for the highest vote count after voting closes.

REQ-10.2: On a detected tie, the system shall open a second discussion thread scoped only to the tied films, open for 24 hours.

REQ-10.3: The system shall open a revote restricted to the tied films after the 24-hour tie-break discussion window closes.

REQ-10.4: If a tie persists after the revote, the Admin's vote shall serve as the deciding vote.

4.11 Admin Confirm & Publish

4.11.1 Description and Priority

Gives the Admin final review and override authority over the determined winner, and locks the result once confirmed. The result is never posted to a public page.

Priority: High

4.11.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

A winner is determined (directly, or via the tie-break process). The system presents the result to the Admin for confirmation. The Admin confirms, or overrides with a logged reason, and the result is locked.

4.11.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-11.1: The system shall present the determined winner to the Admin for confirmation before the result is finalized.

REQ-11.2: The system shall allow the Admin to override the determined winner, and shall require and log a reason for any override.

REQ-11.3: The system shall lock the confirmed result from further changes.

REQ-11.4: The system shall not publish the result, shortlist, or vote data to any public, unauthenticated-facing page; results and discussion access are released only to authenticated Filmmaker accounts as defined in Feature 4.12.

4.12 Post-Publish Result & Comment Visibility

4.12.1 Description and Priority

Once the Admin publishes the final result, gives each shortlisted Filmmaker access to the full jury/admin discussion thread on their own film, alongside the final outcome, providing transparency and usable feedback for the filmmaker's future work.

Priority: Medium

4.12.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Admin publishes the result. The system unlocks the discussion thread and final-result view on the dashboard of each Filmmaker whose film was shortlisted, restricted to their own film only.

4.12.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-12.1: The system shall make the discussion thread for a shortlisted film visible to that film's Filmmaker once the Admin has published the final result.

REQ-12.2: The system shall restrict a Filmmaker's visibility to the discussion thread of their own film only, never another filmmaker's.

REQ-12.3: The system shall display discussion comments to the Filmmaker without attributing them to a specific Jury member or Admin by name, preserving reviewer anonymity.

REQ-12.4: The system shall not make any discussion thread or result visible to a Filmmaker before the Admin publishes the final result.

4.13 Notification System

4.13.1 Description and Priority

Sends private status notifications to the relevant Filmmaker at each key stage of their submission's lifecycle. There is no public results page or audience-facing notification.

Priority: Medium

4.13.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

A tracked status event occurs for a submission (received, eligibility result, shortlist result, or final result). The system sends a notification to the owning Filmmaker only.

4.13.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-13.1: The system shall notify the Filmmaker when their submission is successfully received.

REQ-13.2: The system shall notify the Filmmaker of the outcome of the automatic eligibility check.

REQ-13.3: The system shall notify the Filmmaker whether their film was included in the shortlist.

REQ-13.4: The system shall notify the Filmmaker of the final result, and that their film's discussion comments are now viewable, once the Admin confirms and publishes.

REQ-13.5: The system shall deliver every notification privately to the individual Filmmaker (email and/or in-app); no notification or result shall be posted publicly.

4.14 Admin Audit Trail

4.14.1 Description and Priority

Maintains a chronological, immutable log of every Admin action across the platform, so the Admin can review, verify, and manage festival operations without relying on memory or external notes.

Priority: Medium

4.14.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

An Admin performs a tracked action (jury approval, jury assignment, eligibility override, tie-break resolution, result publish, festival configuration change). The system records the action with a timestamp and appends it to the audit log.

4.14.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-14.1: The system shall log every Admin action — jury approval, jury assignment, eligibility override, tie-break resolution, result publish, and festival configuration changes with a timestamp and the acting Admin's identity.

REQ-14.2: The system shall display the audit trail to the Admin as a searchable, filterable, chronological list.

REQ-14.3: Audit log entries shall be immutable; no edit or delete operation shall be available for existing entries.

REQ-14.4: The system shall restrict audit trail visibility to the Admin of the festival to which the log entries belong.

4.15 Festival Creation & Management

4.15.1 Description and Priority

Allows a Non-Filmmaker to create a new festival — becoming its Admin — and to configure that festival's core settings: name, submission deadline, eligibility rules, and scoring rubric criteria/weights.

Priority: High

4.15.2 Stimulus/Response Sequences

Non-Filmmaker submits a festival creation form (name, dates, eligibility rules, rubric criteria and weights). The system creates the festival record and grants the creator Admin privileges scoped to that festival. The Admin may subsequently edit these settings until the submission window opens.

4.15.3 Functional Requirements

REQ-15.1: The system shall allow a Non-Filmmaker to create a new festival by providing a name, submission deadline, eligibility rules, and scoring rubric criteria with weights.

REQ-15.2: The system shall grant the creating Non-Filmmaker Admin privileges scoped exclusively to the festival they created.

REQ-15.3: The system shall allow the Admin to edit festival settings only before the submission window opens.

REQ-15.4: The system shall prevent a Non-Filmmaker from holding Admin privileges over a festival they did not create.

5. Other Nonfunctional Requirements

5.1 Performance Requirements

- Standard pages (dashboards, forms, shortlist, discussion) shall load within 3 seconds on a typical broadband connection.
- Weighted score aggregation and shortlist generation shall complete within a few seconds of the scoring window closing.

5.2 Safety Requirements

Not applicable in the physical-safety sense. The relevant "safety" concern is data integrity: submitted scores, comments, and votes must not be lost or corrupted, since they directly determine the festival outcome.

5.3 Security Requirements

- Role-based access control shall be enforced server-side for every endpoint, not only hidden in the UI.
- Blind-review identity-hiding (Feature 4.5) shall be enforced server-side, so identity fields are never present in API responses served to the Jury role.
- Reviewer-anonymity for post-publish comment visibility (Feature 4.12) shall likewise be enforced server-side, so Jury/Admin identity fields are never present in API responses served to the Filmmaker role.
- Passwords shall be stored using a salted hash; plaintext passwords shall never be stored or logged.
- All client-server traffic shall use HTTPS.
- Submitted trailer/full-film links shall be validated against a supported-host allowlist (YouTube, Google Drive) before being accepted.
- An immutable audit log of Admin actions shall be maintained to support accountability and post-hoc review.

5.4 Software Quality Attributes

- Usability: each role's dashboard should require no more than brief in-app guidance to use, given the target users are students and volunteer organizers, not trained operators.
- Reliability: no single inactive Jury member should be able to indefinitely block the discussion, voting, or tie-break process; all discussion windows auto-close on a timer.
- Maintainability: the system is built as independently deliverable increments (Auth, Submission/Eligibility, Jury/Scoring, Ranking/Discussion/Voting/Admin Decision, Notifications & Post-Publish Visibility), each with clear module boundaries.
- Portability: the system shall run as a responsive website across current versions of major desktop and mobile browsers, with no native app required.

5.5 Business Rules

- Only the Admin of a given festival may assign films to Jury members approved for that festival, and may confirm/override that festival's final winner.
- A Jury member may review and score only the films explicitly assigned to them.
- A participant's vote is not accepted until they have satisfied the mandatory discussion requirement for every shortlisted film.
- A film submission is not considered complete until the registration payment is confirmed by the payment gateway.
- A Filmmaker may view discussion comments and the final result for their own film only, and only after the Admin publishes.
- Reviewer identity is never disclosed to a Filmmaker, even after publishing to protect Jury/Admin from any post-result pressure.

6. Other Requirements

None identified beyond the requirements captured in Sections 3–5 at this time. Database schema details, internationalization, and legal/compliance requirements (if any, e.g. around storing minors' content or copyright of submitted films) are candidates for a future revision and are listed in Appendix C.

Appendix A: Glossary

- **Filmmaker:** A registered user who submits a film for consideration in the festival.
- **Non-Filmmaker:** A registered user who has not yet committed to a role. Becomes an Admin by creating a festival, or a Jury member by requesting and being approved to join one.
- **Jury Member:** A Non-Filmmaker approved by a festival's Admin to review films for that specific festival, after requesting to join it.
- **Admin:** A Non-Filmmaker who created a specific festival, holding jury-approval, jury-assignment, shortlist-oversight, and final-confirmation authority scoped to that festival only.
- **Blind Review:** A scoring mode in which the filmmaker's identity is withheld from the Jury during review.
- **Shortlist:** The system-generated, ranked Top 5 list of films by aggregate weighted score.
- **Tie-Break:** The scoped secondary discussion-and-revote process used to resolve a tied final vote.
- **Weighted Rubric:** A scoring form in which each criterion (e.g., story, direction, technical quality) contributes a different, predefined weight to the total score.
- **Post-Publish Visibility:** The stage, beginning once the Admin publishes the final result, at which a shortlisted Filmmaker gains read-only access to the anonymized discussion comments on their own film.

Appendix B: Analysis Models

Winner-Decide Process Flow (described narratively; see accompanying diagram exported from project discussions):

- 1. System generates the Top 5 shortlist from aggregate weighted jury scores.
- 2. Mandatory discussion phase opens (comment thread per shortlisted film, 48-hour window); voting stays locked per participant until they have commented on every film.
- 3. Final voting opens once a participant meets the comment requirement; each Jury member and Admin casts one vote.
- 4. System auto-tallies votes; highest vote count wins if there is no tie.
- 5. If tied, a second discussion (24 hours, scoped to tied films only) is followed by a revote restricted to those films; if still tied, the Admin's vote decides.
- 6. Admin confirms and publishes the result; the result and the film's discussion thread become visible to that film's Filmmaker only, with reviewer identities kept anonymous. No public page is ever created."

Process Model: the system is developed using the Incremental Model, in five increments — (1) Auth, role-based access & festival creation, (2) Submission & eligibility, (3) Jury assignment, blind review & scoring, (4) Ranking engine, discussion, voting & Admin decision, (5) Notifications, Post-Publish Visibility & Audit Trail

Appendix C: To Be Determined List

- TBD-1: Exact rubric criteria and their individual weights for scoring.
- TBD-2: Confirm whether the shortlist size remains fixed at Top 5 or becomes Admin-configurable.
- TBD-3: Final deployment/hosting platform for the web application (e.g., local Tomcat for demo vs. a free-tier host such as Render or Railway).
- TBD-4: Whether a separate user manual will be produced for a future release, beyond V1.0's in-app help text.